CHAPTER 5

Decisions: A Brief History of Democracy and Totalitarianism

Democracy and dictatorship are typically discussed as contrasting political and ethical systems. This chapter seeks to shift the terms of the discussion, by surveying the history of democracy and dictatorship as contrasting types of information networks. It examines how information in democracies flows differently than in dictatorial systems and how inventing new information technologies helps different kinds of regimes flourish.

Dictatorial information networks are highly centralised.[1] This means two things. First, the centre enjoys unlimited authority; hence information tends to flow to the central hub, where the most important decisions are made. In the Roman Empire all roads led to Rome, in Nazi Germany information flowed to Berlin, and in the Soviet Union to Moscow. Sometimes the central government attempts to concentrate *all* information in its hands and to dictate *all* decisions by itself, controlling the totality of people's lives. This totalising form of dictatorship, practised by the likes of Hitler and Stalin, is known as totalitarianism. But not every dictatorship is totalitarian. Technical difficulties often prevent dictators from becoming totalitarian. The Roman emperor Nero, for example, didn't have the means to micromanage the lives of millions of peasants in remote provincial villages. In many dictatorial regimes considerable autonomy is therefore left to individuals, corporations and communities. However, dictators always retain the authority to intervene in people's lives. In Nero's Rome freedom